

SCALES SUCK, THE END.

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #200

I am going to end the Digging Deeper Jazz series the way I began it 200 weeks ago. By making the point that scales are NOT the best path to jazz improvisation success for most of us, most of the time. Should you practice scales on your instrument? Yes. Can we use scales as a basis for improvisation? Sure. Are they the best point of departure. Definitely not.

Chord tones, on the other hand, do NOT suck. They are great, and they are your goal. Most melodies, and most great jazz solos are comprised mostly of chord tones. No exaggeration. 70% + chord tones, almost without exception. Be like your heroes, and put down the scales.

Get good with 1) chord tones, 2) anticipations, 3) neighboring notes, and 4) passing notes.

#1 - Solo/Etude over "My Shining Hour"

The musical notation is presented in four staves, each with a key signature of one flat (Bb) and a 4/4 time signature. The notation includes various jazz chords and melodic lines with annotations:

- Staff 1:** Chords: Cmaj7, Am7, Dm7, G7. Annotations: (anticipation) under the Dm7 chord, (anticipation) under the G7 chord.
- Staff 2:** Chords: Cmaj7, Am7, Dm7, Bø7, E7(b9). Annotations: (neighbor tone) under the Cmaj7 chord, (anticipations) under the Bø7 and E7(b9) chords.
- Staff 3:** Chords: Am7, Bø7, E7(b9). Annotations: (passing tone) under the Am7 chord, (neighbor tone) under the Bø7 chord, (anticipation) under the E7(b9) chord.
- Staff 4:** Chords: Am7, D7, Dm7, G7. Annotation: (yes, a scale!) under the D7, Dm7, and G7 chords.